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NETWORK SCHOOL

Reimagining land or community?

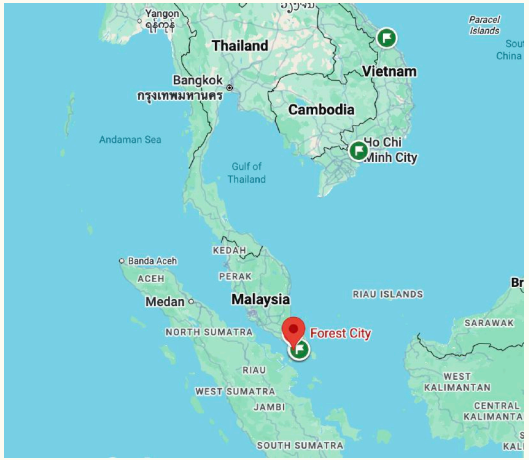
Forest City

NICKNAME

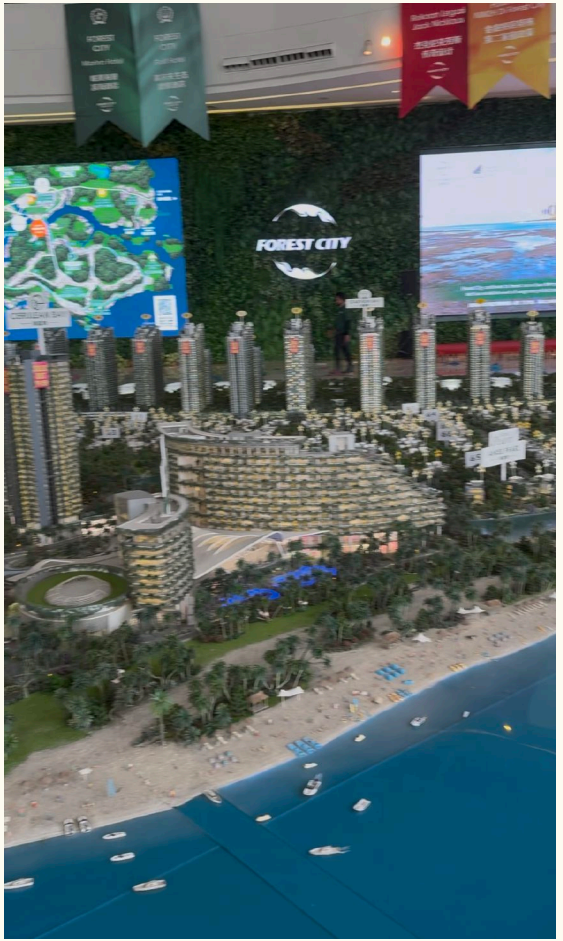
“Jewel of the south”

LOCATION

Johor, Malaysia - on the Singapore border







Initial idea



Why it failed

CURRENCY CONTROLS

Chinese buyers limited to spending only $50,000/year outside of China since 2020

MALAYSIAN POLITICAL CRISIS

Crisis from 2020-2022 created disruption in local government in support of the project.

COVID RESTRICTIONS

Limitation of movement reduced desire for second homes

DELAYS IN SEZ FRAMEWORK

Establishment of Duty Free tax allowances only implemented in 2024, further tax freedoms implemented at the end of 2024 (attracting new interest from family offices in 2025)

Network School, Forest City

THE SETUP

Five-star hotel repurposed as a startup live/work community

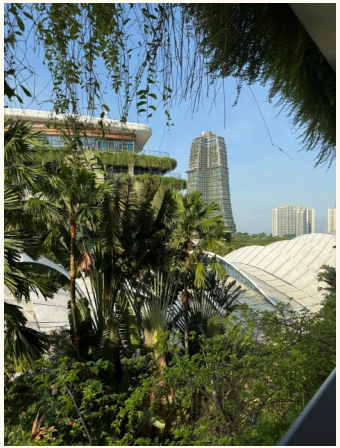
THE PITCH

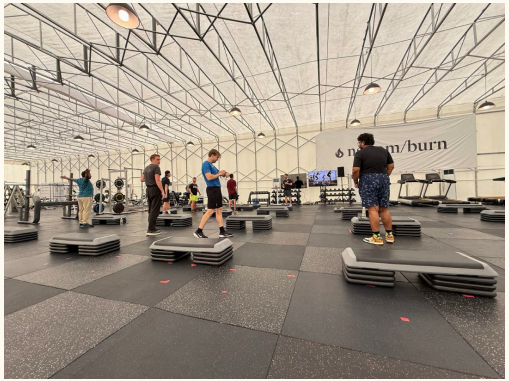
"A new San Francisco" - the ultimate startup city

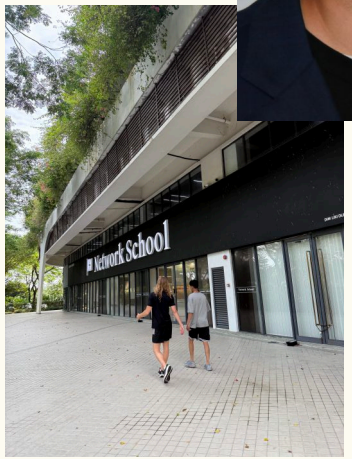
INFRASTRUCTURE

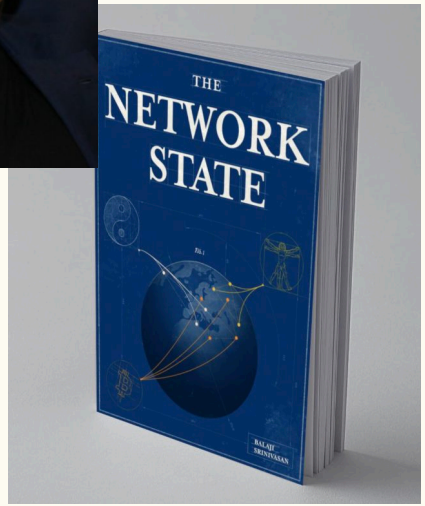
Workstations, fast wifi (most of the time), meals you just turn up for, gym, pool











What is a Network State?

> "A highly aligned online community with the capacity to crowdfund territory towards eventual diplomatic recognition."
>
> **Balaji Srinivasan - The Network State, 2022**

01

Digital community

Shared values, online coordination, a mission

02

Physical presence

Meetups, Pop-up cities
Permanent Territory - owned, leased, or crowdfunded

03

Diplomatic recognition

The hardest part. Legitimacy from the outside world

Also within the movement

01

Charter cities / SEZs

Eg. Prospera - land projects that negotiate some level of regulatory autonomy - Prospera describes as having around 80% autonomy.

02

Sovereignty projects

Eg. Sealand, Liberland - focus on claiming “unclaimed territory” or international waters, unstable for investment and business incorporation

03

Pop-up cities

Eg. Edge City - temporary gatherings which take over existing villages, lasting 1-2 months. Important for community building.

04

Parallel polities

Eg. Logos, Traditional Dream Factory - Blockchain based operations, “residents” live in existing systems/towns but operate most things online like internal governance structures, crypto currency economies and Web3 companies.

Population

Rolling cohorts

Startup founders there for a month or two at a time in a central hotel

Long term population

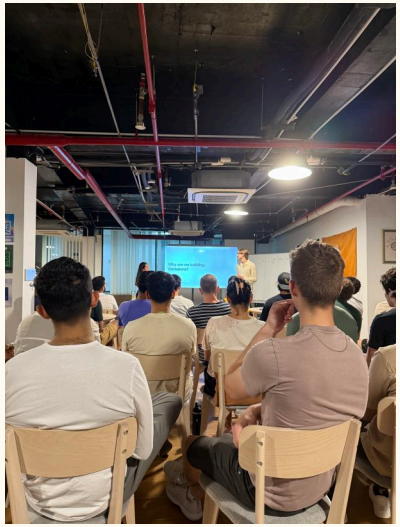
Smaller population who have signed 12 month leases and are in privately leased apartments

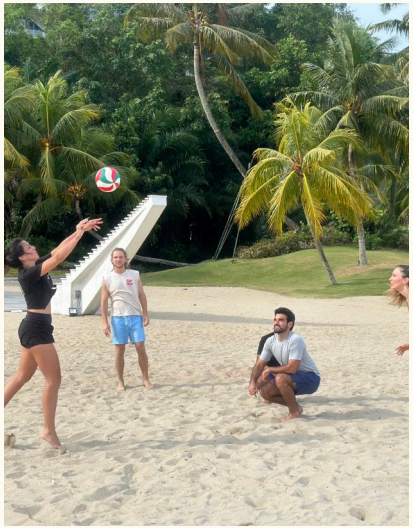


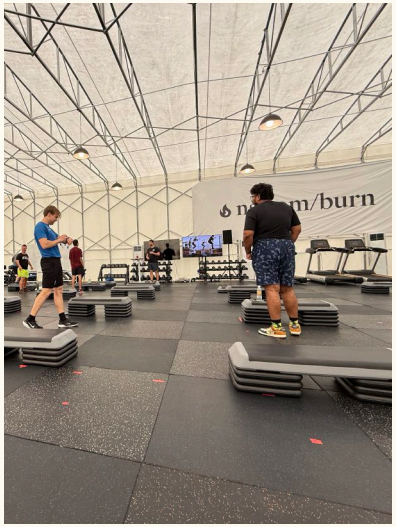
250 residents total

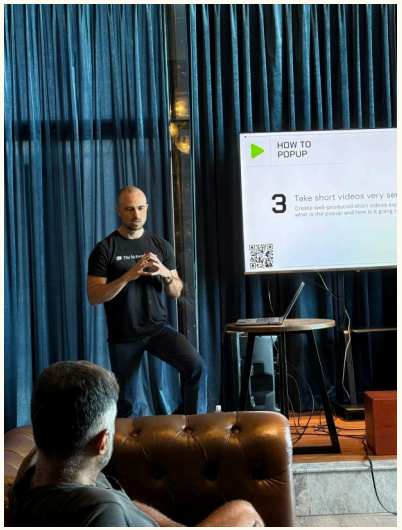
130 long term sign ups

Daily life







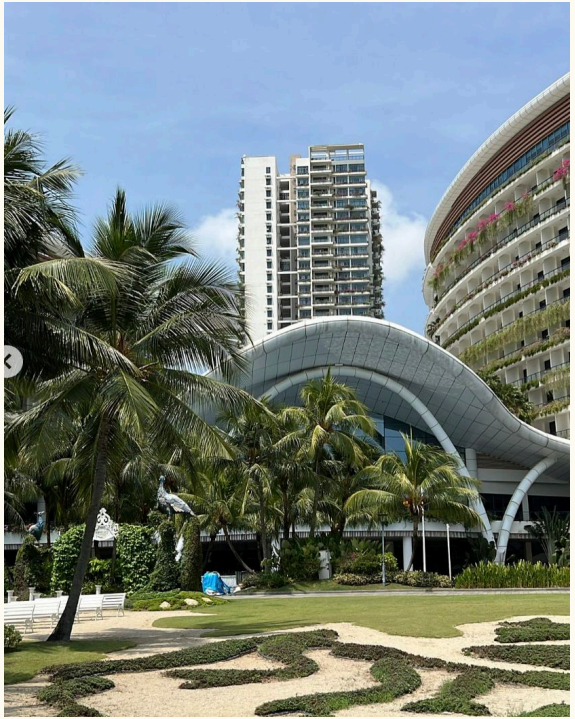


The Community Architecture

01 NETWORK SCHOOL

The infrastructure experiment

~250 residents, marketed as competitive entry, transient digital nomads and startup founders. Open but curated - deciding to go was in itself a filter.







The Community Architecture

02 ÂRC

Layer two - chosen family

Sub-community within NS. Focus on constitutions, religion, governance, long-term societal design. Daily check-ins, exclusive sessions, exclusive "club lounge", mechanism for belonging.







Social structures





The Friction

1. **The pressure cooker dynamic**
   Small community, gossip spreads fast. One wrong move could create a social pariah overnight.
2. **Location as liability**
   Forest City felt like a ghost town. Limited outside contact. Those from cities felt it most acutely.
3. **Narrative control**
   A lot of focus from leadership on making sure public narrative is explicitly positive - can come across as inauthentic and dismissive of community concerns.
4. **The always-on intensity**
   The ambient pressure to perform productivity was constant many people that were there more than a few months needed to leave and come back to decompress.

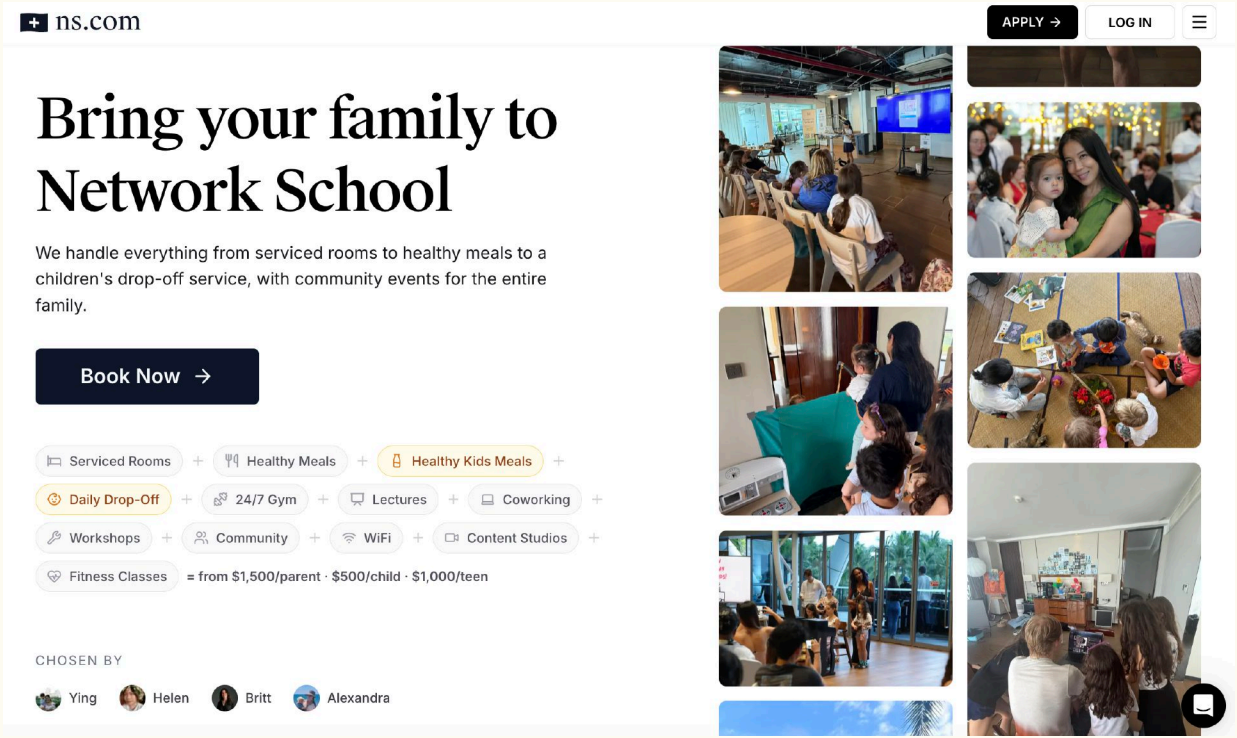
The Friction

4. Lack of development

The main differentiator from digital nomad co-living at the moment is hope that it will be more than it is. The vision is not yet reality and they are struggling to retain long term residents.



Families


ns.com
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Bring your family to Network School
We handle everything from serviced rooms to healthy meals to a children's drop-off service, with community events for the entire family.
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Serviced Rooms
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24/7 Gym
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Coworking
Workshops
Community
WiFi
Content Studios
Fitness Classes
= from $1,500/parent · $500/child · $1,000/teen
CHOSEN BY
Ying
Helen
Britt
Alexandra

The critical mass problem

LACK OF INFRASTRUCTURE

Don't yet have a focus on infrastructure or culture to compete with other global cities or attract families long term

MANY FOCUSED ON DIGITAL NOMADS

A demographic that is open to moving but very mobile and often leave after a few months

The critical mass problem

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INVOLVEMENT OF LOCAL POPULATION

NS actively cuts itself off. Other projects are starting to involve local population but provision of jobs will be the turning point.

LITTLE FOCUS ON COMMUNITY BUILDING

Many founders of permanent projects aren't involving potential residents in their development or focused on building community



What's this all about?

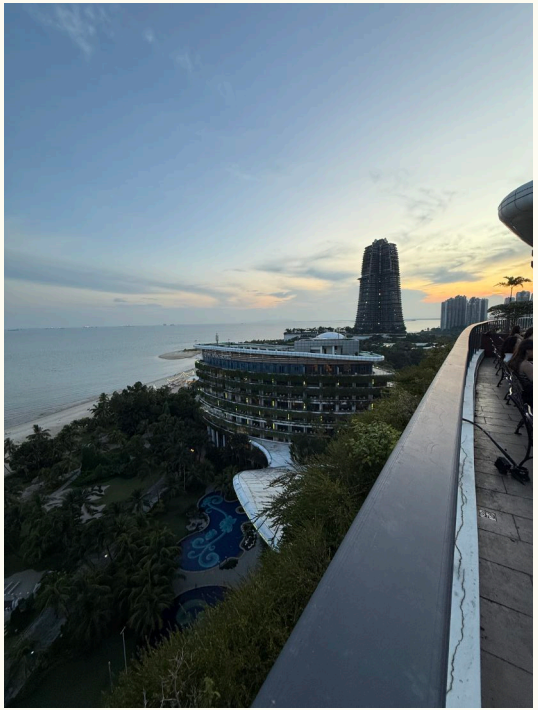
If it is about reimagining land...

- Only makes sense if it has real territory

- Must solve some of the issues prevalent in existing systems housing, civic engagement, sovereignty

- Must be permanent - not a retreat or co-living stay



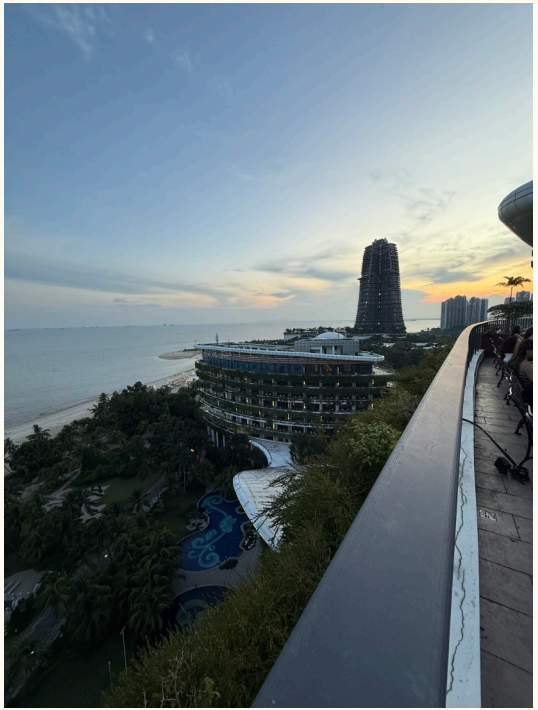


What's this all about?

If it is about reimagining land...

- Needs to create economic opportunities and incentives to stay and grow the permanent population





What’s this all about?

If it's about belonging...

- The real innovation is in the social layer, not the land

- The territory is a symbol of permanence - the community is the product

